defence production by using the vast strategic assets in the Central Asian republics.

Fourth, the SCO has been successful in containing the spread of extremism and terrorism in Central Asia, primarily because of China's constant interests and engagement with these states. Still, the region could emerge as the next hotbed of sectarian conflict. The existing SCO states constitute a Muslim population of almost 100 million of the Sunni/Salafi variant with affiliation to Saudi Arabia and Pakistan. Especially Chechnya, the Ferghana Valley, and Xinjiang could become the arc of future instability. The SCO Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS) could play a vital role in observing trends in radical political Islam spreading in the Ferghana Valley and across the Amu Darya into Afghanistan and Pakistan. India therefore needs to understand the emerging trends in the region, and this is best achieved from inside the SCO.

Fifth, the SCO could offer India some unique opportunities to engage constructively with Eurasia addressing shared security concerns, especially for combating terrorism but also containing threats posed by ISIS and the Taliban. India's participation in the SCO's military and counter-terror exercises could prove beneficial for its armed forces to understand and interact with other militaries, thereby instilling greater confidence at the regional level. Moreover, the SCO is a potential platform for cooperation in non-conventional security areas such as food security and drug-trafficking control, as well as information and cyber security.

Sixth, India sees its entry into the SCO as essential for protecting its own interests in Afghanistan in the aftermath of the withdrawal of US forces. Although both the SCO and the Russia-led Collective Security Treaty Organ-isation (CSTO) are unlikely to play more than a "defensive" role,[7] India could provide a value addition in terms of generating a positive political environment for Afghan peace. While a